pursuit of only political power. He had transformed into someone who was touching the lives of people and making them realize that they were cared for. He was making people feel loved. He was making them feel important. There was a different kind of determination in his eyes, a steely resolve, a different spring in his step. This wasn't just his Yatra to unite or his version of the discovery of India—it was a chance for the nation to pause, ponder and reflect.

The Yatra changed many things. It redefined Indian politics, to begin with. It changed people's expectations and the political discourse. And it certainly changed what people in public life should strive for.

The Yatra changed me on various levels. It certainly changed my relationship with Rahul ji. From being my leader and someone I greatly admired, he became someone who inspired me to be a better human being. Here was someone who walked the talk on virtues that he spoke about, someone who wasn't afraid to stand up for the right cause, no matter how steep the price. Someone who proved that politics wasn't just about the naked pursuit of power, but a means to unite people, to talk about the importance of love. A means to ensure women were made to feel like partners instead of just ornamental additions.

I believe the Yatra changed Rahul ji too. He has spoken on several occasions about how his need to speak was replaced by the desire to listen. Love and respect, the kind he evoked, cannot leave someone untouched.

But it wasn't always a smooth ride. While visuals of people eager to meet their leader were heart-warming, they also made some of us worry about Rahul ji's physical and personal safety. No one in the Yatra was frisked—anyone who wanted to meet him could do so freely. People came in from all directions. Given the hate that the political ecosystem fuels against my leader, this was a legitimate concern. But he didn't care, he was happy to be amid his fellow Indians. He was there to listen to them, to say, 'No matter what the odds, I will stand with you.' I remember being worried on one such occasion and voicing my concerns to him. He didn't bat an eyelid before saying, 'I am going to walk, no matter what. If something happens, so be it.' That day, walking with the courage of your convictions